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Context Matters

*A Beginner's Guide to Reading
the Bible in Its World*

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Introduction

You picked up this book because something nagged at you while reading the Bible.

Maybe it was a passage that felt strange — a command that made no sense in your world, a metaphor that seemed to assume you already knew something, a moment where Jesus said something cutting and the crowd reacted in a way you couldn't quite track.

Or maybe it was a sermon, a thread you scrolled past on social media, a podcast that mentioned in passing that a verse meant something different than you'd always thought. And the new meaning, once you heard it, made the whole passage click into place.

You realized: the Bible was written in a world that is not yours. People in that world knew things you don't. They ate different food, fought different battles, told different jokes, feared different gods. And the writers of Scripture wrote to those people, in their language, with their assumptions.

That doesn't mean the Bible isn't for you. It is. It just means there is a step you have to take before it can land the way it was meant to land.

That step is called *historical context*. And it's what this book is about.

I wrote this for the people who follow our work at contextscripture.org and who keep asking us the same question in different forms: *Where do I start? How do I learn to read this way? Is there a book?*

There are excellent books, and I will point you to them. But many of them assume you already know things — that you've been to seminary, that you have time for four hundred pages, that you can read Hebrew and Greek. This book assumes none of that.

It assumes you love the Bible. It assumes you want to read it well. It assumes you are willing to take a little time to learn how.

It is short on purpose. You should be able to finish it in a long afternoon. By the time you do, you will have a framework, a vocabulary, and a small library of resources for going deeper.

You will also, I hope, have something more important: a posture. A way of approaching the text that takes the original audience seriously, that resists the urge to flatten Scripture into a self-help guide, and that lets the Bible surprise you again.

Let's begin.

Part One

Why Context Matters

The Bible Was Not Written to You

Here is a sentence that sounds wrong at first: the Bible was not written to you.

It is, of course, written *for* you. Christians have always believed that the same Scripture given to Israel, to the early Church, and to the prophets is the Scripture that speaks to us today. The Spirit who breathed those words has not stopped breathing.

But — and this is the difference — those words were not addressed to you, in your zip code, in your century, in your language. They were addressed to people who lived a long time ago, in a place far from yours, in a culture you have never visited.

When Paul wrote to the church at Corinth, he was not imagining you. He was imagining a port city in Greece, full of new converts arguing about food sacrificed to idols and head coverings and which preacher they liked best. The questions he answered were their questions. The shorthand he used was their shorthand.

When Moses wrote to Israel, he was not imagining you. He was writing to a people who had just walked out of Egypt, who were forming a nation under the shadow of Pharaohs and Canaanite kings, who needed to know who they were and whose they were.

Every page of the Bible was written *to* somebody — and that somebody was not you.

This matters because the Bible is not a magic book. It does not work like a horoscope, where you flip to a verse and it pops into focus regardless of what came before or what comes after. It is not a fortune cookie. It is a library of letters, laws, songs, stories, and visions — each one written by a specific person, to a specific audience, at a specific moment, for a specific reason.

If you want to know what a verse means *for you*, you have to first know what it meant *to them*. There is no shortcut.

Why This Isn't Bad News

Some readers find this discouraging at first. *I just want to read my Bible. I don't want to do homework.*

I understand. But here is the good news: learning the original context is not homework. It is the part where the Bible gets interesting.

Most of the time, when people give up on reading the Bible, it is because it feels flat. The same verses, the same vague applications, the same sermons. Adding context is what makes it three-dimensional. Suddenly the parables sting again. Suddenly the prophets are not strange — they are devastating. Suddenly Jesus is not a calm wisdom-teacher floating above his world but a man who chose his words with surgical precision, knowing exactly what they would do to the people in front of him.

If you have ever felt that the Bible has gone quiet, context is one of the things that can bring it back to life.

The Two Horizons

Bible scholars often talk about two horizons: the horizon of the text and the horizon of the reader. The horizon of the text is the world in which it was written. The horizon of the reader is the world in which it is read.

Good reading happens when those two horizons meet. Not when the reader's horizon is forced onto the text — that gives you a Bible that always agrees with you, which is a strange kind of Bible — and not when the text's horizon is treated as a museum piece — that gives you a Bible that has nothing to say to you, which is also strange.

The aim is a conversation. You bring your questions. The text brings its world. Honest reading happens in the meeting between the two.

This book is about the first half of that meeting. The half a lot of readers skip.

What Historical Context Really Means

When people say “historical context,” they often mean a hundred different things. Let’s get specific.

Historical context, for our purposes, is everything outside the text that helps you understand what is inside the text. It is the air the original audience breathed without thinking about it.

It includes at least four things.

Cultural context. The values, customs, taboos, and assumptions of the original audience. How families worked. What honor meant. What shame meant. What it meant to be a host, a guest, a slave, a freedman, a child, a woman, a king. These categories often look very different from ours.

Geographical context. Where things happened. What the land looked like. How long it took to walk from Galilee to Jerusalem. What it meant to live in the wilderness, or the hill country, or the coastal plain. Geography in the Bible is often theology in disguise — when Jesus goes up or down, when a prophet flees to the sea, when a city is built on a hill, the place is doing work the writer expects you to feel.

Political and economic context. Who was in charge. Who was paying taxes to whom. What the empire was doing to the people. Why Roman soldiers were on the streets of Jerusalem. Why a tax collector was the most hated man in his village. Why a Pharisee and a Sadducee disagreed.

Religious context. The other gods in the air. The temples nearby. The festivals being celebrated. The arguments inside Judaism in the first century. The categories of clean and unclean, sacred and profane, in and out.

You don’t need to master all four to read the Bible well. But you need to know they exist, and you need to be willing to ask questions of the text from each angle.

An Example

Take a famous verse: “*Behold, I stand at the door, and knock*” (Revelation 3:20).

You have probably seen this verse on a Sunday school painting — Jesus, robed and gentle, knocking at a door with no handle on the outside, waiting patiently for the sinner to open up. The standard application: Jesus is asking to come into your heart.

There is nothing wrong with the application, exactly. But notice what context does to it.

This verse is in a letter — one of seven letters in Revelation written to actual churches in actual cities. The church in question is Laodicea. Laodicea was a wealthy city, known for its banking, its black wool, and its eye salve. It was also famous for one annoying problem: its water came from a distant hot spring and arrived lukewarm. The Laodiceans knew exactly what lukewarm water tasted like, because they drank it every day. It made you spit.

And this is *not* a letter to an unbeliever. It is a letter to a church — Christians who had let their wealth and self-sufficiency dull their devotion. Jesus is not standing politely outside the heart of a stranger. He is standing outside the door of his own people, the people who said they belonged to him but had stopped letting him in.

The image is sharper. The rebuke is sharper. The grace is sharper. He could have walked away. Instead he knocks.

That is what context does. It doesn't replace the verse. It puts the verse in three dimensions.

What Context Is Not

A quick word on what historical context is *not*.

It is not a secret decoder ring. Some teachers act as if historical context unlocks hidden meanings that no ordinary reader could see — as if every verse has a Greek pun or a rabbinic backstory and unless you know it you are missing the real message. That is not honest. The Bible is not a code, and most of its meaning is accessible to careful readers who pay attention to what is in front of them.

It is also not a license to override the plain sense of the text. If a verse clearly says something, context cannot make it say the opposite. Context illuminates; it does not erase.

And it is not the same as personal application. Knowing what a verse meant to the original audience is the first step, not the last. The final step — what does this mean for me, here, now? — still matters. But you cannot do step two well without doing step one.

With those guardrails in place, let's go look at the world the Bible was written in.

Part Two

The World Behind the Text

The Old Testament World

The Old Testament was written over roughly a thousand years, in three languages (mostly Hebrew, some Aramaic, plus a sprinkling of others). It tells the story of one people — Israel — surrounded by other peoples whose stories were also being told.

You cannot read the Old Testament well without some sense of the *ancient Near East*. This is the world of Mesopotamia (modern Iraq), Egypt, the Levant (modern Israel, Palestine, Lebanon, Syria, Jordan), and the smaller nations between them. It is a world of city-states, empires, irrigation canals, war chariots, and gods.

The Gods Next Door

Here is the single most important thing to remember about the Old Testament world: it was full of gods.

Every nation had them. Every city had them. Some were creator-gods, some were storm-gods, some were fertility-gods, some were patron-gods of particular places. They were imagined as living among their people, sometimes physically housed in temples that fed and dressed them. The boundary between religion and politics was nonexistent — your god was your king's god, and your king's god was your god.

Into this world, the God of Israel introduces himself. He is not housed in a temple at first. He is not local. He is not one god among many. He makes promises to a wandering man named Abraham, leads his descendants out of slavery, gives them a law, and gradually reveals that he is not just *their* god. He is *the* God.

The Old Testament is, in part, a slow argument with the gods of the neighborhood. When the prophets mock idols, when the psalmist asks who is like the Lord, when the storytellers describe walls falling down at trumpet blasts and rivers parting at the touch of a staff — they are saying *our God is not like their gods*. He is not a stone. He is not a fertility cycle. He is alive. He acts in history. He keeps his word.

If you read the Old Testament without that backdrop, the constant warnings against idolatry sound paranoid. With the backdrop, they sound urgent. The pull was real. Israel kept giving in. The prophets kept calling them back.

Empires and Exile

A second thread that shapes the Old Testament is empire. Israel was a small nation in a hard neighborhood. To the south, Egypt. To the east, Assyria, then Babylon, then Persia. To the west, the Mediterranean and eventually the Greeks and Romans.

Most of the Old Testament was written under the shadow of one of these empires. Some of it — Daniel, parts of Ezra and Nehemiah, much of the late prophets — was written *from inside* one of them. The questions empire forces on a faithful people — how do we live here? do we resist? do we assimilate? do we wait? — are everywhere in these books.

If you read the Bible as if Israel lived in a vacuum, you will miss the pressure under which it was written. The exile, in particular, is one of the most important events in the Old Testament. After it, nothing in Jewish life was the same. The exile is the wound that the rest of the Old Testament — and arguably the New Testament — is trying to heal.

Honor, Land, and Family

A few more things to know about the cultural air.

Honor and *shame* were the operating system. Your standing in the community mattered more than your inner state. To be shamed was a real catastrophe. To honor or shame your family was a real act.

Land was theology. To have land was to have the blessing of God. To lose land was to be cursed. Boundary stones were sacred. Genealogies, which can feel tedious to modern readers, are about who is connected to which land — which is to say, who belongs.

Family was identity. There were no isolated individuals. You were your father's son. You were your tribe's member. Decisions belonged to households, not selves. To disown a family was to disown a self.

When you read the Old Testament with these in view, things that looked strange — long lists of names, obsessions with property lines, brothers fighting over a blessing — become urgent. They are about who you are, where you stand with God, and whether you will still exist tomorrow.

The New Testament World

By the time we get to the New Testament, the world has changed.

The Jewish people are back in their land, but their land is under Roman occupation. The Old Testament's promises about the Messiah, the kingdom, and the return of God have not been fulfilled in any obvious way. The temple has been rebuilt, then expanded by a half-Jewish king named Herod, but God has not visibly returned to it. There are tax collectors on the streets, soldiers at the gates, and a rotating cast of priests cooperating with the occupying power.

This is the world Jesus walks into.

Second Temple Judaism

The Judaism of Jesus' day is sometimes called *Second Temple Judaism*, after the temple Herod was busy expanding. It was not a single, uniform religion. Imagine four men in the same room. All loyal Jews. All reading the same Scriptures. All waiting for God to act. All convinced the others were getting it wrong.

The *Pharisees* were lay teachers focused on applying the Law to everyday life. They built fences around the commands — extra rules to make sure you did not accidentally break the main rules. They were popular and influential.

The *Sadducees* were priestly aristocrats. They controlled the temple. They cooperated with Rome to keep their position. They rejected the resurrection of the dead and accepted only the first five books of the Bible as fully authoritative.

The *Essenes* withdrew. They thought the temple was corrupted and the Pharisees were compromised. They went into the wilderness and waited for God.

The *Zealots* did not wait. They wanted to drive out Rome by force, and they would eventually do so — triggering the disastrous war of A.D. 66–70 that ended with the temple being burned to the ground.

And then there were the ordinary people — the crowds. Fishermen, farmers, day laborers, mothers, beggars, lepers. Tired, taxed, and waiting.

When Jesus speaks, he speaks into this room. He is not floating above it. He is in it. He spars with Pharisees because they are the ones who care about the Law in his way. He clashes with Sadducees because they own the temple he is critiquing. He attracts crowds because the crowds are exhausted and have been waiting for someone like him.

The Roman World

The wider world was the Roman Empire, ruled by an emperor who was increasingly being called *son of god* and *lord* and *savior*. Roman roads connected the cities. Roman armies kept the peace. Roman taxes paid for both. Greek was the common language of commerce and writing. Cities like Corinth and Ephesus were melting pots — gods from everywhere, people from everywhere, ideas from everywhere.

This is the world Paul writes into. When he calls Jesus *Lord*, he is using a word that has a Caesar attached to it. When he announces *good news*, he is using a word imperial heralds used to announce a Caesar's victory. He is not borrowing imperial language by accident. He is making a claim.

When the early Christians refused to call Caesar Lord, refused to burn incense to the emperor, refused to participate in the public religion of the city, they were not being eccentric. They were committing what looked like treason. The persecutions you read about in the New Testament make more sense once you see what was being asked.

A World of Patrons and Clients

One more piece of cultural background: the *patron-client* relationship.

In the Roman world, most people did not stand on their own. They were attached to a patron — someone wealthier and more powerful — who provided protection, opportunity, and resources. In exchange, the client provided loyalty, honor, votes, and presence. Patronage ran all the way up. Even Caesar had patrons (the gods). Even gods had clients (their worshipers).

This is the texture under a lot of New Testament language about grace. *Grace* (Greek: *charis*) was a patron's gift — unearned, but creating an obligation to respond with loyalty and gratitude. When Paul says we are saved by grace, he is using a word the original audience knew from their daily lives. The point was not just that the gift was free. The point was that it changed your allegiances. You now belonged to a new patron.

Honor, shame, gods, empire, patrons. This was the air. Once you can feel it, the New Testament reads differently.

Honor, Shame, and the Cultural Air

Of all the cultural categories in the Bible's world, the one most likely to mislead modern Western readers is *honor and shame*.

We do not live in an honor-shame culture. We live in a guilt-innocence culture (with some innocence-guilt thrown in). In our world, what matters most is what is *true about you internally* — whether you are guilty or innocent, sincere or hypocritical, faithful or unfaithful in your own private conscience.

In an honor-shame culture, what matters most is what is *true about you publicly* — whether the community sees you as honorable or shameful, whether you have brought credit or disgrace to your family, whether you have a face you can show in town tomorrow.

This is not better or worse than our system. It is just different. And the Bible was written by and to people who lived inside it.

Examples

Once you start to see honor and shame, you see them everywhere.

When Joseph, betrothed to Mary, finds out she is pregnant, he plans to “put her away privily” (Matthew 1:19). Modern readers often read this as a private legal matter. It was actually about shame. The public discovery of a pregnant betrothed would have ruined her in the village. Joseph's restraint is not legal; it is *honorable*. He absorbs cost to protect her.

When the prodigal son returns and his father runs to meet him (Luke 15:20), we read it as warm and fatherly. The original hearers read it as scandalous. Dignified Middle Eastern fathers did not run. To run, the father would have had to hitch up his robes and expose his legs — a deep shame in that world. He is publicly humiliating himself to spare his son the village's wrath. The grace becomes physical.

When Jesus tells people to take the lowest seat at a banquet (Luke 14:7–11), he is not giving an etiquette tip. He is exposing the entire honor-grasping system. His followers are to stop playing the game.

When Paul writes that he is “not ashamed of the gospel” (Romans 1:16), he is making a statement that would have been startling. In an honor-shame world, to follow a crucified man — and crucifixion was the most shameful death the empire could devise — was, by definition, dishonorable. Paul says: *I will wear that dishonor*. The new honor is in Christ.

Reading with New Eyes

When you start to ask *where is honor in this story? where is shame? who is gaining face? who is losing it?* — many passages open up.

You also start to notice how *radical* Jesus is. Again and again, he overturns the honor-shame economy. He touches lepers, eats with tax collectors, lets a sinful woman wash his feet, hands honor to people who have none. He absorbs shame and gives away honor. It is not that he ignores the system; he subverts it.

That is harder to feel if your operating system is guilt-innocence. The cross, in particular, is harder to feel. To us, the cross is primarily about substitution — Jesus dying in our place to take away our guilt. That is true. But in the original world, the cross was also about *shame* — Jesus taking the world’s deepest dishonor and turning it, on the third day, into the world’s deepest glory. Both readings are biblical. Most modern readers only see one.

Honor and shame are not the only cultural categories worth knowing. Purity. Hospitality. Kinship. Covenant. Each of these would reward a chapter of its own. But honor and shame are the foundation. Get this one, and the rest get easier.

Part Three

How to Read Any Passage in Context

Six Questions to Ask Every Time

So far, we have been talking about context in the abstract. Now let's get practical.

When you sit down with a Bible passage — say, the verse a friend sent you, the chapter your small group is reading, the paragraph that came up in your devotional — you do not need to become a scholar to read it well. You need a habit. A simple set of questions to ask before you ask the big one (*what does this mean for me?*).

Here are six.

1. Who wrote this, to whom, and when?

Every book of the Bible has an author (or several), a primary audience, and a moment. Some of these are easy: Paul wrote 1 Corinthians to the church in Corinth around A.D. 55. Some are harder: scholars debate when Job was written, who wrote Hebrews, what the original audience of the Gospel of Matthew looked like.

You do not need to settle every debate. You need to know *enough* to imagine the original audience. If you are reading 1 Corinthians, picture a port city full of Greek-speaking new Christians arguing about meat. If you are reading Hebrews, picture Jewish Christians being tempted to drift back into the old system because the new one was costing them too much.

A study Bible can answer this question for you in two minutes per book. Get a good one and use it.

2. What kind of writing is this?

The Bible is a library, not a book. It contains law, history, poetry, prophecy, wisdom, gospel, letter, and apocalyptic — at least. Each kind has its own rules.

You cannot read poetry the way you read law. You cannot read apocalyptic the way you read history. You cannot read a parable the way you read an epistle.

If you have ever wondered why Revelation is so weird, this is part of the answer: it is *apocalyptic*, a genre with conventions (symbolic numbers, vivid imagery, cosmic struggle) that the original audience knew well and that we have to learn.

Chapter Seven will say more about genre. For now: every time you open the Bible, ask what kind of book you are in.

3. What is the literary context?

Before you ask about the historical context, ask about the literary context. What comes before this verse? What comes after? What is the chapter about? What is the book about?

Most misreadings of the Bible come not from a lack of ancient history but from a lack of basic reading attention. People pluck verses out and float them like balloons. Verses do not float. They are tied to paragraphs, which are tied to arguments, which are tied to whole books.

A simple test: can you state in one sentence what the chapter is doing? If you can, you are in good shape. If you cannot, you have not finished reading.

4. What is the historical and cultural context?

Now bring in what we have been talking about. What was the world like? What did the original audience know that I do not? What category am I missing — honor? purity? patronage? empire? geography?

You will not always have an answer. Sometimes you will need to look something up. A good background commentary (recommendations later) will give you most of what you need in a sentence or two.

The question is not *what hidden meaning does the historical context unlock?* The question is *what was the original audience hearing that I am not hearing?* Sometimes the answer is nothing important. Sometimes the answer changes everything.

5. Where does this passage fit in the larger story, and where is Christ in it?

The Bible is one story. From Genesis to Revelation, it tells a single arc: creation, fall, the calling of a people, the long preparation for a redeemer, the coming of Christ, the spread of his kingdom, and the renewal of all things. Every passage sits somewhere in that arc.

On the road to Emmaus, the risen Jesus walked with two disciples and, *“beginning at Moses and all the prophets, he expounded unto them in all the scriptures the things concerning himself”* (Luke 24:27). That moment is a key. Faithful Christian reading does not stop at the verse. It asks how the verse fits the story — and how the story finds its center in him.

This does not mean you have to find Jesus hiding behind every bush. It means the redemptive arc is the air the whole library breathes, and your reading should breathe it too. A psalm of lament reads differently when you hear it against the cross. A law about sacrifice reads differently when you hear it as a long preparation for the one who would offer himself once for all. A promise to Israel about returning from exile reads differently when you hear it as a foretaste of the deeper homecoming Christ has secured.

The Christ-pattern can take several honest shapes — foreshadowing (the Passover lamb pointing toward the Lamb of God), promise kept (a word God will fulfill in Christ), contrast (a failed Israelite pointing forward to the faithful Israelite), or fulfillment (the cross gathering up everything earlier into one moment). Each is honest. None requires forcing the text.

Ask the question gently. Sometimes the connection is direct. Sometimes it is faint. Sometimes the passage is doing other work first and the Christ-pattern shows up only at the wider level. But never skip the question.

6. What does this passage say about God, about us, and about how we should live?

Only now — after the first five questions — do we get to application. And even here, we do not jump to what do I do? first. We ask:

What does this say about God? Every passage is, in some way, a revelation of who he is. What does this one show?

What does this say about us? What does it tell us about human beings — our hearts, our condition, our possibilities?

What does this say about how we should live? In light of who God is and who we are, what response is the passage calling for?

This order matters. If you start with application, you tend to turn the Bible into a self-help book. If you start with God, you read the Bible the way it was meant to be read — as a window onto him.

These six questions are the framework. The rest of the book is variations on them.

Genre Matters

A short tour of the major genres in the Bible and how to read each.

Law (Exodus through Deuteronomy, mostly)

The Law is not just a list of rules. It is a covenant document — a treaty between God and a people he has just rescued. Read it as a love language as much as a rule book.

When you encounter a strange law — about mixing fabrics, about field boundaries, about sacrifices — ask: what was it teaching Israel about who God is and who they are? Many of the laws are about *holiness* — being set apart from the surrounding nations, set apart for God's purposes.

Some laws have direct application today; many do not. The principle is what carries forward. The aim — a people belonging fully to God — is the same.

Narrative (Genesis, the historical books, Acts)

The Bible tells stories. A lot of stories. Story is the dominant mode of Scripture, and yet many readers don't know how to read it.

Three rules for reading biblical narrative:

The narrator is rarely preachy. The text usually does not tell you and this was bad or and this was good. It shows. You have to read with attention to what the characters do, what the consequences are, and what the wider story is saying.

Description is not endorsement. The Bible records many things it does not approve of. Just because David did something does not mean David should have done it. Just because Abraham lied about Sarah does not mean lying was right. Read with discernment.

Look for the patterns. Biblical narrative is rich with echoes — one story echoes an earlier one, characters mirror each other, scenes are set up to invite comparison. Noticing the patterns is a big part of reading well.

Poetry (Psalms, Song of Solomon, much of the Prophets)

Hebrew poetry does not rhyme. It runs on *parallelism* — one line echoing, intensifying, or contrasting another. “The heavens declare the glory of God; and the firmament sheweth his handywork” (Psalm 19:1).

Poetry is also dense with metaphor. When the psalmist says God is a rock, he does not mean God is mineral. When the psalmist says his enemies are like dogs, he does not mean they bark. Reading poetry as if it were prose flattens it.

The Psalms also model an emotional honesty many of us are unused to. The psalmist yells at God. Despairs. Doubts. Celebrates. Demands. He does not pretend. Read the Psalms as prayers, not just hymns.

Prophecy (Isaiah through Malachi, plus parts elsewhere)

The prophets were not primarily fortune-tellers. They were covenant prosecutors. Their job was to confront a people who had broken the covenant, call them back, warn of consequences, and promise restoration.

When you read a prophet, expect:

Indictment. Here is what you have done. Often graphic. Often furious.

Sentence. Here is what is going to happen because of it. Often terrifying.

Hope. Here is what God will do in the end, despite everything. Often dazzling.

The future-telling parts of prophecy were usually about the near future — the exile that was coming, the deliverance that would follow. Some of them also pointed forward to something larger — the coming Messiah, the renewal of all things. Reading prophecy well means holding both horizons.

Wisdom (Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Job)

Wisdom literature describes the world as it generally is, not as it always is. Proverbs are not promises. “Train up a child in the way he should go: and when he is old, he will not depart from

it” (Proverbs 22:6) is not a guarantee; it is a wise observation, true *in general* in a well-ordered life.

Ecclesiastes and Job exist in part because the simple proverbs do not always hold. The world is more complicated than a tidy maxim. Wisdom literature lets you sit in that tension.

Gospel (Matthew, Mark, Luke, John)

The Gospels are not biographies in the modern sense. They are theological portraits — careful arrangements of stories about Jesus, designed to make particular claims about who he is and what he came to do.

Each Gospel has a perspective. Matthew emphasizes Jesus as the new Moses and the fulfillment of Israel’s story. Mark is fast, urgent, focused on the cost of following. Luke emphasizes the outsiders — women, the poor, Samaritans, Gentiles. John meditates on Jesus as the eternal Word.

When you notice that the same story is told differently in different Gospels, do not panic. The differences are usually intentional. Each writer is shaping the story for his own audience and his own argument.

Epistle (Romans through Jude)

Letters. Real letters, written to real churches and individuals, in response to real situations. You are reading someone else’s mail.

When you read an epistle, always remember: there is half a conversation you cannot hear. The writer is responding to questions, problems, and arguments you do not have access to. A good study Bible will fill in the gaps.

Apocalyptic (Daniel, parts of Ezekiel, Zechariah, Revelation)

The hardest genre for modern readers. Apocalyptic literature uses vivid, often bizarre symbolic imagery to depict cosmic conflict and ultimate hope. It was written for oppressed people, in a code their enemies could not crack but their friends could.

Do not read it as a flat newspaper account of future events. Read it as a vision, designed to comfort the persecuted and unsettle the powerful. Look for the central message — God reigns, evil will fall, the saints will be vindicated — rather than getting lost in the imagery.

Worked Examples

Theory is one thing. Practice is another. Let's walk through four short passages, using the six questions, and see what changes.

Example 1: "The eye of a needle" (Mark 10:25)

"It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle, than for a rich man to enter into the kingdom of God."

You may have heard a popular explanation that the eye of the needle was a small gate in Jerusalem's wall, and a camel could squeeze through if it knelt and was unloaded. The lesson, on that reading: rich people can enter the kingdom, but they have to humble themselves.

The explanation is charming. It is also almost certainly false. There is no archaeological or historical evidence for such a gate. The earliest source for the story is medieval, long after Jesus.

So what did Jesus mean?

Who, to whom, when? Jesus, to his disciples and a crowd that included a rich young ruler who had just walked away sad. First century, Galilee.

What kind of writing? Gospel narrative containing a saying of Jesus. Sayings of Jesus often use deliberate exaggeration to make a point.

Literary context? This comes right after the rich young ruler refuses to sell what he has. Jesus is grieving with him, and then turns and says this. The disciples are astonished.

Historical context? In Jewish thinking of the time, wealth was often seen as a sign of God's favor. If someone as blessed-looking as the rich young ruler can't enter the kingdom, who can? That is exactly what the disciples ask next: "Who then can be saved?"

Where in the story / where is Christ? The whole Gospel is driving toward the cross, where the impossible thing happens — God himself making the way for those who could not save themselves. The rich young ruler walks away because he cannot give up what he has. Jesus is

walking toward Jerusalem to give up everything he has, opening the way into a kingdom no one could enter on their own.

What does it say? It says the kingdom is impossible to enter on our own merit — not just for the rich, but for anyone. The camel is meant to be absurd. The point is impossibility. And Jesus' next line is the punch: "With men it is impossible, but not with God: for with God all things are possible" (Mark 10:27).

The eye-of-the-needle gate erases the point. Context restores it.

Example 2: "I know the thoughts that I think toward you" (Jeremiah 29:11)

"For I know the thoughts that I think toward you, saith the Lord, thoughts of peace, and not of evil, to give you an expected end."

This may be the single most-decontextualized verse in modern Christianity. It is on graduation cards. It is on coffee mugs. It is the verse a friend sends you when you did not get the job, or did not get into the school, or did not get the diagnosis you wanted. The standard application: God has a wonderful plan for your individual life, full of peace and prosperity, and the future will be bright.

There is something true under that application. But the verse, in context, is doing something much harder, and much more beautiful.

Who, to whom, when? Jeremiah, to the Jewish exiles deported to Babylon, around 594 B.C.

What kind of writing? A letter — an actual letter Jeremiah sent from Jerusalem to the exiles in Babylon. Jeremiah 29 reproduces the letter in full.

Literary context? The letter begins by telling the exiles to settle in. Build houses. Plant gardens. Get married. Have children. Pray for the welfare of Babylon. Why? Because — and this is the key — God says in verse 10: "After seventy years be accomplished at Babylon I will visit you, and perform my good word toward you, in causing you to return to this place." Verse 11 comes immediately after. The expected end is the end of the seventy years.

Historical context? The exiles were in despair. They had lost the temple, the city, the king, the land. False prophets were telling them the exile would be short. Jeremiah's letter says: it will not be short. You will live and die here. Your children will live and die here. Only your

grandchildren's generation will go home. But — and this is the promise — God has not abandoned you. The thoughts he thinks toward you are thoughts of peace. He will bring you home, in his time, on the far side of a generation you will not live to see.

Where in the story / where is Christ? The seventy-year promise was kept. The exiles came home. But the deeper exile — the alienation between God and his people that the Babylonian exile only dramatized — was healed not in 539 B.C. but at the cross. The “expected end” Israel waited for arrives in full only in Christ, who brings his people home from a longer exile than Babylon.

What does it say? The verse is not a promise that your life will be free of suffering. It is a promise that on the far side of long, painful, generation-spanning loss, God's intentions toward his people are good. It is a promise for people in exile, told they are going to stay in exile for a lifetime, that God has not forgotten them.

That is more comforting than the graduation-card version, not less. The graduation-card version cannot hold you when the diagnosis is bad, when the marriage fails, when the years go by and the door does not open. The original verse can. It was written for people whose doors would not open in their lifetime — and it told them that God's faithfulness ran past the horizon of what they would see.

Example 3: “Be ye not unequally yoked” (2 Corinthians 6:14)

“Be ye not unequally yoked together with unbelievers: for what fellowship hath righteousness with unrighteousness? and what communion hath light with darkness?”

The common modern application: don't marry an unbeliever.

Who, to whom, when? Paul, to the church at Corinth, around A.D. 55–56.

What kind of writing? Epistle.

Literary context? This is in the middle of a passage about the integrity of Paul's ministry and the church's witness. The discussion is not about marriage. The wider concern is the Corinthians' continued involvement in pagan religious practices — including temple meals — that compromised their identity as God's people.

Historical context? The metaphor of a yoke comes from agriculture: two animals harnessed together to pull a plow. An unequally yoked team — say, an ox and a donkey — could not pull straight. The image is of two creatures trying to do shared work while pulling in different directions.

The wider passage uses sharp covenantal language — righteousness against unrighteousness, light against darkness, Christ against Belial (Paul’s word for a satanic counter-power) — which suggests the concern is structural fellowship between God’s people and a way of life ordered against him. In Corinth, one pressing form of this was *temple participation*: pagan temples were the center of the city’s social and economic life, and to eat at their tables was to share, even partly, in the worship of other gods. Marriage, business, and ongoing religious partnership all sit inside the same wider concern.

Where in the story / where is Christ? To be yoked to Christ is the deepest and most freeing yoke — “my yoke is easy, and my burden is light” (Matthew 11:30). To be yoked at the same level to a power that pulls the other way is to be torn between two masters.

What does it say? The principle extends to marriage — being yoked for life to someone who pulls toward different gods is a sober matter. But the original force is wider: any deep, ongoing partnership — business, religious, intimate — with people whose deepest allegiances run counter to Christ’s will create a tension that is structural, not just emotional. The verse is not a list of rules. It is a warning about who you tie your life to.

Notice how the context did not narrow the verse. It widened it. Read carelessly, it sounded like a marriage rule. Read in context, it became a principle about every deep partnership in your life.

Example 4: “I can do all things through Christ” (Philippians 4:13)

“I can do all things through Christ which strengtheneth me.”

Painted on locker room walls. Tattooed on the inside of arms. Printed under athletes’ eye black. The standard application: with Christ on my side, no goal is too big — I can win the game, ace the exam, close the deal, accomplish what I set out to accomplish.

In context, the verse is almost the opposite of that.

Who, to whom, when? Paul, to the church at Philippi, around A.D. 60–62. Paul is writing from prison.

What kind of writing? Epistle. The closing personal section of the letter.

Literary context? The verses immediately before are everything: “Not that I speak in respect of want: for I have learned, in whatsoever state I am, therewith to be content. I know both how to be abased, and I know how to abound: every where and in all things I am instructed both to be full and to be hungry, both to abound and to suffer need” (Philippians 4:11–12). Then comes verse 13. The “all things” Paul can do are the all things he just listed: being hungry, being full, having plenty, having nothing.

Historical context? Paul is in chains. He has spent his ministry getting beaten, shipwrecked, hungry, betrayed, and abandoned. He is writing to a church that has just sent him a financial gift, and he is thanking them while being careful to say: I am not desperate. I have learned that whether I have or do not have, Christ is enough.

Where in the story / where is Christ? Paul’s contentment is not stoic. It is the strength of being “in Christ” — the one who himself learned obedience through what he suffered and turned a Roman cross into a throne. Paul’s peace in a prison cell is a small foretaste of resurrection life: the kind of life that endures everything because it is grounded in someone the grave could not hold.

What does it say? The verse is not about winning. It is about the strength to lose well. It is about being able to be hungry without falling apart, and being able to have plenty without forgetting whose you are. The all things Paul can do through Christ is the all things of contentment — the all things of being secure in him whether the circumstances are good or terrible. On a championship banner, the verse is a wish. In context, the verse is a witness from a prison cell.

Many Christians live with the painted-locker-room version their whole lives and are quietly disappointed every time circumstances do not bend their way. The verse, rightly heard, would set them free. It is not a promise that they can do whatever they want. It is a promise that they can endure whatever comes.

This is what good contextual reading does. It almost always makes the Bible say more, not less.

Part Four

Going Deeper

Building Your Context Library

You do not need a library of three hundred books to read the Bible in context. You need a small, well-chosen set of tools. Here is what I would buy first if I were starting over.

A Good Study Bible

A study Bible is your daily workhorse. Its notes will answer most of the questions this book has been raising. Recommendations:

ESV Study Bible — conservative-evangelical, deep notes, beautiful maps. The standard for many.

NIV Cultural Backgrounds Study Bible (edited by John Walton and Craig Keener) — built specifically around the question this book is built around. Notes on cultural and historical background on every page. If you can only have one, consider this one.

The Jewish Annotated New Testament — the New Testament with notes from Jewish scholars. Wildly illuminating for understanding the Jewish context of the New Testament.

A Background Commentary

When the study Bible notes aren't enough, a background commentary is your second stop.

IVP Bible Background Commentary: Old Testament by John Walton, Victor Matthews, and Mark Chavalas.

IVP Bible Background Commentary: New Testament by Craig Keener.

These go through the Bible verse by verse and tell you what the original audience would have heard. They are not theological commentaries — they will not tell you what a verse *means* — they will tell you what the verse *assumed*. That is what you want.

A Primer on the World of the Bible

To get a feel for the world, a couple of accessible reads:

Misreading Scripture with Western Eyes by E. Randolph Richards and Brandon J. O'Brien — focuses on the modern Western assumptions that distort our reading.

Jesus Through Middle Eastern Eyes by Kenneth E. Bailey — illuminating on the Gospels, especially the parables.

Reading the Bible with Rabbi Jesus by Lois Tverberg — Jewish background for the Gospels, written for ordinary readers.

A Book on Method

How to Read the Bible for All Its Worth by Gordon Fee and Douglas Stuart — the standard introduction. Covers every major genre and how to read it. Worth its weight.

Theological Depth and Intertextuality

As you grow, two horizons will start to matter more: how each verse fits the whole canon, and how Scripture should be read theologically, not just historically. Six short(ish) books to grow into:

Scripture and the Authority of God by N. T. Wright — short, accessible, and clarifying on what it means to take the Bible seriously as Scripture, not just as ancient literature.

Commentary on the New Testament Use of the Old Testament edited by G. K. Beale and D. A. Carson — when a New Testament writer quotes the Old, this volume tells you what they were doing with it. Use it as a reference, not a cover-to-cover read.

Echoes of Scripture in the Letters of Paul by Richard B. Hays — the classic study of how Paul reads the Old Testament. Slow, dense, and rewarding.

According to Plan by Graeme Goldsworthy — the best short introduction to reading the Bible as one unfolding story that climaxes in Christ.

Is There a Meaning in This Text? by Kevin Vanhoozer — for when you are ready to slow down and ask the deeper questions about meaning, authors, and readers.

Reading Jesus's Bible by John Goldingay — a short, accessible guide to how the New Testament reads the Old. A natural bridge between background and theology.

A Historical Atlas

Zondervan Atlas of the Bible by Carl Rasmussen, or any solid Bible atlas. Geography is theology in the Bible. Seeing it on a map helps.

That is the starter kit, plus a deeper shelf. You can build it over a year or two, one book at a time, as you grow into them.

A Note on the Internet

You can find a lot of good context content online — including, immodestly, ours. Use it. But cross-check. The internet rewards confident assertions; not all confident assertions are right. The eye-of-the-needle gate we debunked above is one example. Treat any one online source the way you would treat any single voice — useful, possibly wrong. The published, peer-reviewed scholars are not infallible either, but they have been checked harder.

Habits for a Lifetime of Contextual Reading

A book ends. Habits go on. If reading the Bible in context is going to actually shape how you read for the rest of your life, you need a few habits to carry it. Here are six.

1. Always read the surrounding paragraph.

When a verse comes up — in a devotional, on social media, in a sermon, in your own quiet time — read the paragraph it sits in. Then read the chapter, or at least know what the chapter is doing. This single habit will protect you from most misreadings.

2. Ask “what kind of writing is this?” before you ask anything else.

Train yourself to notice genre. Are you in a parable? A psalm? A law? A letter? Each one calls for different ears.

3. Use a study Bible.

Not as a replacement for your own reading — as a companion. Read the text. Then check the notes. Then read the text again. You will be surprised how often something in the notes lands.

4. Learn one new piece of background each week.

You do not need to study constantly. Pick up one fact a week — about a city, a custom, a Hebrew word, a Roman practice — and let it sit. Over a year, you will know fifty things you did not know before. Over a decade, the world of the Bible will start to feel familiar.

5. Read whole books in one sitting.

Most modern Christians read the Bible in tiny daily fragments. The original audience often heard whole books read aloud at one go. Try it. Sit down with a cup of coffee and read all of Philippians, or Ruth, or 1 John, or Mark. You will notice things you have missed for years.

6. Read with someone.

The Bible was almost never meant to be read alone. From Israel hearing the Law in assembly to the early church passing around Paul's letters, Scripture has always belonged in community. Find one person, or a few, and read together. Disagree. Argue. Pray. The text will open up.

These six habits are simple. They are also enough. You do not need a degree in biblical studies to be a faithful reader. You need attention, humility, and a willingness to learn.

Conclusion: An Invitation

You started this book because you wanted to read the Bible better. I hope you are leaving it with a clearer sense of what that means.

It does not mean becoming a scholar. It does not mean mastering Hebrew and Greek. It does not mean replacing the Spirit's work in your reading with academic detachment.

It means taking the Bible seriously enough to ask what it actually said, to the people it was actually written to, in the world they actually lived in. It means closing the distance, as much as you can, between their world and yours. It means letting the Bible surprise you, as it kept surprising the people who first heard it.

There is a moment many readers describe — the moment when a familiar verse opens up because they finally saw what was around it. The verse does not change. The reader does. The Bible has been saying it the whole time; the reader has just learned to hear it.

That moment can happen again and again, for the rest of your life. I hope this book has set you up for many of them.

Keep reading. Keep asking the questions. Keep finding people to read with. And when something opens up — when a passage clicks for the first time, when a hard verse finally lands — share it. Tell someone. That is how the work goes on.

Grace and peace.

Appendix: The Six-Question Framework

A printable summary you can keep in your Bible or beside your reading chair.

Before you ask *what does this passage mean for me?*, ask:

1. Who wrote this, to whom, and when?

Picture the original audience. Imagine the room.

2. What kind of writing is this?

Law, narrative, poetry, prophecy, gospel, epistle, wisdom, or apocalyptic? Each is read differently.

3. What is the literary context?

What comes before? What comes after? What is the chapter doing? What is the book doing?

4. What is the historical and cultural context?

What did the original audience know that you do not? What category is in play — honor, purity, patronage, geography, empire?

5. Where does this passage fit in the larger story, and where is Christ in it?

Find the passage on the redemptive arc. Don't skip the question even when the answer is faint.

6. What does this passage say about God, about us, and about how we should live?

Start with God. Then us. Then application.

Use these every time. They will become second nature. And they will change how you read.

Recommended Reading

The books mentioned in Chapter Nine, gathered here for your reference with publishers and editions.

Study Bibles

- NIV Cultural Backgrounds Study Bible, ed. John H. Walton and Craig S. Keener (Zondervan, 2016)
- ESV Study Bible (Crossway, 2008)
- The Jewish Annotated New Testament, ed. Amy-Jill Levine and Marc Zvi Brettler (Oxford University Press, 2nd ed. 2017)

Background Commentaries

- The IVP Bible Background Commentary: Old Testament — John H. Walton, Victor H. Matthews, and Mark W. Chavalas (IVP Academic, 2000)
- The IVP Bible Background Commentary: New Testament — Craig S. Keener (IVP Academic, 2nd ed. 2014)

Primers on the World of the Bible

- Misreading Scripture with Western Eyes — E. Randolph Richards and Brandon J. O'Brien (IVP Books, 2012)
- Jesus Through Middle Eastern Eyes — Kenneth E. Bailey (IVP Academic, 2008)
- Reading the Bible with Rabbi Jesus — Lois Tverberg (Baker Books, 2017)
- Walking in the Dust of Rabbi Jesus — Lois Tverberg, with afterword by Ann Spangler (Zondervan, 2012)

Method

- How to Read the Bible for All Its Worth — Gordon D. Fee and Douglas Stuart (Zondervan, 4th ed. 2014)

- How to Read the Bible Book by Book — Gordon D. Fee and Douglas Stuart (Zondervan, 2002)

Theological Depth and Intertextuality

- Scripture and the Authority of God — N. T. Wright (HarperOne, rev. ed. 2011)
- Commentary on the New Testament Use of the Old Testament — ed. G. K. Beale and D. A. Carson (Baker Academic, 2007)
- Echoes of Scripture in the Letters of Paul — Richard B. Hays (Yale University Press, 1989)
- According to Plan: The Unfolding Revelation of God in the Bible — Graeme Goldsworthy (IVP Academic, 1991)
- Is There a Meaning in This Text? — Kevin J. Vanhoozer (Zondervan, 1998)
- Reading Jesus's Bible: How the New Testament Helps Us Understand the Old Testament — John Goldingay (Eerdmans, 2017)

Atlases

- Zondervan Atlas of the Bible — Carl G. Rasmussen (Zondervan, rev. ed. 2010)

Going Deeper

- The Lost World of Genesis One — John H. Walton (IVP Academic, 2009)
- The New Testament in Its World — N. T. Wright and Michael F. Bird (Zondervan, 2019)
- Backgrounds of Early Christianity — Everett Ferguson (Eerdmans, 3rd ed. 2003)

These books are listed in roughly the order I would buy them. Start with a study Bible and the background commentaries. Add the rest as your curiosity grows.

Happy reading.

Context Matters

The Bible was written in a world that is not yours. People in that world knew things you do not. The writers of Scripture wrote to those people, in their language, with their assumptions. This short guide will give you the framework, the vocabulary, and the small library you need to read it the way it was meant to be read.

What you'll learn:

- Why the Bible was not written to you — and why that's good news
- The world behind both Testaments: gods, empires, honor, shame, patrons
- A six-question framework you can use on any passage
- Four common misreadings, set right — Mark 10:25, Jeremiah 29:11, 2 Corinthians 6:14, Philippians 4:13
- A starter library of trusted books for going deeper

Distributed freely. Share it.

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